Week 19

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 5 · LESSON 3

Deity

BIG IDEA

Don't assume students believe Jesus is God; many admire Him as a good moral teacher without following Him as Lord. This lesson centers on who Jesus claims to be and asks students who they say He is, and why.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. The speaker once assumed every student believed Jesus is God; a doorstep conversation with two young Mormons showed how differently people can mean "Jesus."
2. John 8 is the focus because Jesus states plainly who He is, "Before Abraham was born, I am," the claim that made the religious leaders want to kill Him.
3. The intro activity asks students who they think they are and what evidence backs it up; if Jesus says who He is and the evidence supports it, that matters.
4. Large group can include gentle, respectful interaction about the evidence for who we, and others, claim to be.
5. Expect the "good moral teacher" view: admiring Jesus' teaching while refusing Him as God, because accepting Him as God means being accountable to Him.
6. Ask, as Jesus asked Peter in Matthew 16, "Who do you say I am?" Then ask why, and what it would take to see Him as God: not enough evidence, or not willing?

SCRIPTURE IN THE VIDEO John 8 · Matthew 16

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Have I assumed my students see Jesus the way I do, without ever asking them?
2. Where do I treat Jesus' teaching as optional advice instead of the word of my Lord?
3. How might knowing where each student stands change how I pray for them?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. When Jesus said, "Before Abraham was born, I am," what do you think He was claiming?
2. Why do you think so many people admire Jesus as a teacher but stop short of calling Him God?
3. What changes for someone if Jesus is God and not only a good moral teacher?
4. Who do you say Jesus is, and what has shaped your answer?
5. What kind of evidence would matter most to you in deciding who Jesus is?

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WEEK 19 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Do they believe Jesus is God?

0:05 When you're talking to your students about Jesus, do you automatically assume that they believe Jesus to be God? For years I did. I just assumed it, until I got into a conversation with them about it and realized that that's not always the case. Not that long ago, I was talking with a couple of young guys who came to my door. They were Mormons.

0:37 They were super nice and very friendly, and I had a great conversation with them. Naturally I went right to talking about Jesus, because at first we agreed on a ton of things, which I expected to be the case. But then, once we started talking about Jesus, although it seemed like we were going to agree, I very quickly realized that where I thought we would disagree is exactly where I thought we would disagree. And I went right to John 8. What I love about this passage is that Jesus just flat out says it. He says who he is, which is partly why — almost entirely why — the Pharisees and the religious leaders want to kill him, because Jesus says, "Before Abraham was born, I am."

1:22 And I asked these guys, what do you think Jesus means here? What do you think this is? They stumbled over it, and they really couldn't come up with a good answer, so they flipped to another passage and started talking about something different. I tried to redirect them back, and it reminded me of a lot of the conversations that I've had with students over the years — and of me making that mistake of just assuming that when we talk about Jesus, we're talking about the same thing.

Who Jesus claims to be

1:53 So it's very possible that even in your context, when you talk about Jesus, you may be talking on a different plane than some of your students are. But this is a great opportunity to be crystal clear on exactly who it is that Jesus actually is, and who he says he is. That's why we have students focus right in on John 8, because it's here that Jesus makes the flat-out statement, "Before Abraham was born, I am." The focus here is who Jesus claims to be.

The intro activity

2:23 So we ask students in the intro activity to put down who they think they are, what their family and friends would say about them, and then whether that matches up. And do they have evidence for this? They think they're somebody — they think they're a soccer player, or a Christian, or a musician, or a football player, or whatever. Do they have evidence for it? I used to call myself a football player because I played football, but a person once brought it up to me and said, "You don't really play football." I said, "Well, what do you mean?" He said, "Well, you sit the bench." So was I really a football player? Probably not so much. So who do they think they are, and what evidence do they have for it?

2:59 So the trick of it is that if Jesus says who he is, and we have evidence for who he says he is, now we've got something. If someone says they're a basketball player and they scored 35 points the night before, they're clearly a basketball player. There's evidence for it. So this is the time you can actually have your students do some of this interaction — nicely and gently and with respect, of course — with each other in your large group time, to get at this idea of: do I have evidence for who I think I am? And do I have evidence for who somebody else thinks that they are? So it would be a good opportunity to do some of that interaction.

Just a good moral teacher

3:40 In your small group time, one thing that I bet is probably going to come out — and you'll want to make sure your small group leaders are ready to deal with it — is this: it's not hard, I don't think, to look at Jesus as a great moral teacher, as someone who has this wonderful religious sage kind of vibe going on, where they can read what he says about love and forgiveness and acceptance and mercy and justice and all these great things that Jesus talks about, like in the Sermon on the Mount, and leave it there.

4:16 And then go on and say, "I'm going to try to follow what Jesus says as a good moral teacher, but I'm not ready to accept him as the God of the universe, the creator of all — because if I accept him as the God of the universe and the creator of all, that has wider implications for me than I'm ready to accept."

4:37 See, it's easy to accept him as a good moral teacher, because I can choose to ignore his teachings if I so choose to. I can do whatever I want when I want. And when I choose to follow his teachings, I look awesome. If I don't, no one's really going to notice. But if I'm held accountable to the God of the universe, that's a whole other story.

What I saw in my students

4:59 So believe it or not, one thing that I found among some of my students back when I was teaching was that a lot of students really loved Jesus and really liked what he taught, but had very little to no intention of ever following him as God. And that bothered me. It was right there. It was under my nose, and half the time I don't even know if I noticed it. But after a while it became very apparent, once I started looking for it. So it changed the way I taught, and it changed the way I started to converse with some of my students, and I started to challenge them.

Who do you say I am?

5:37 And I think small group, in this time and in this lesson, might be a perfect opportunity for you to challenge your students with this question: how do you see Jesus? It's similar to how Jesus addressed Peter in Matthew chapter 16 — "Who do you say I am?" Ask your students, who do you say Jesus is? And when they answer you, whatever their answer is, ask them why. Get some answers out of them as to why they think that.

6:07 And if they're in that place where Jesus is just a good moral teacher, ask them what it would take to get them to see him as God. Is there enough evidence? I mean, you've presented the evidence, and there's a whole bunch of it. If you look through all the verses, we've only given you a spattering of the verses that show that Jesus is God. So what does that mean for them? Is there not enough evidence, or are they just not willing? It can be an eye-opening experience.

6:33 I'll be honest: I'm not telling you if there's anything you can actually do about it physically right at this moment. But it definitely will change the way you approach those students, the way you address them, the way you teach them, the way you pray for them. So I would encourage you to dive into that. It's sort of a scary place to dive into, a little bit, but I would encourage you to do that.